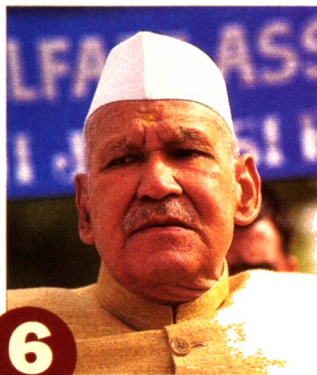


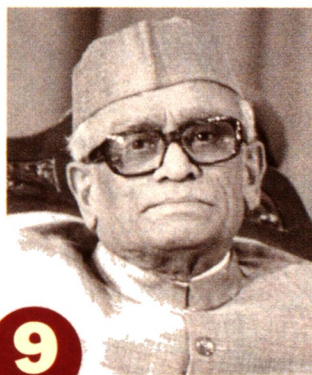


**S.D. SHARMA
(1992-1997)
STICKLER FOR RULES**

An Indira loyalist, swore in Vajpayee under dubious circumstances.

Constitutional Propriety	6
Independence	5
Integrity	6
Stature	5
New Initiatives	4

6



**N. SANJEEVA REDDY
(1977-1982)
SYNDICATED**

Deprived Jagjivan Ram the chance to be the first Dalit prime minister.

Constitutional Propriety	5
Independence	4
Integrity	4
Stature	4
New Initiatives	3

9

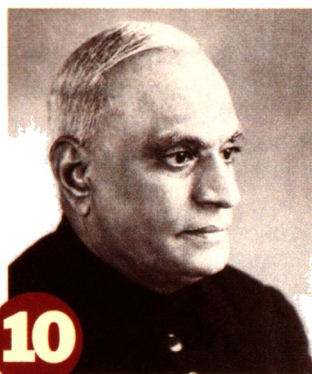


**R. VENKATARAMAN
(1987-1992)
BLAND MANAGER**

Though a constitutional expert, his tenure was largely uneventful.

Constitutional Propriety	5
Independence	5
Integrity	6
Stature	5
New Initiatives	4

7



**V.V. GIRI
(1969-1974)
LEADER'S CHOICE**

Won after Indira's call for conscience vote against Syndicate candidate.

Constitutional Propriety	4
Independence	4
Integrity	4
Stature	3
New Initiatives	4

10

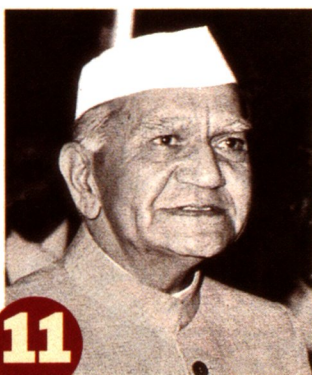


**K.R. NARAYANAN
(1997-2002)
POWER SYMBOL**

The first Dalit President, ideologically inclined to the left-liberal.

Constitutional Propriety	5
Independence	5
Integrity	5
Stature	4
New Initiatives	5

8



**FAKHRUDDIN A. AHMED
(1974-1977)
STAMP DUTY**

Signed proclamation of Emergency without asking for cabinet approval.

Constitutional Propriety	3
Independence	2
Integrity	3
Stature	2
New Initiatives	2

11

tions, particularly to Alexander, Vajpayee, as is his wont, surprised everyone by proposing Kalam's name. While the Left raised strong objections, the Congress was trapped: it could hardly object to a Muslim, a scientist of great distinction and an icon of the middle class. Kalam's candidature may have been a masterstroke on the part of Vajpayee (it was in the wake of the

horrific Gujarat riots when Muslims were insecure and were being treated with suspicion), but it also exposed Kalam's main weakness.

For all his commitment and integrity, Kalam was politically naïve, not surprising for a man who all his life had been a scientist and technocrat. It was clearly that naiveté which put him in an embarrassing spot when he was

persuaded by the United National Progressive Alliance (UNPA) to seek a second term. Though he pulled out in the nick of time, it gave the impression of a man eager to continue in office even though the ruling United Progressive Alliance (UPA) had already made it clear he would not get its support. He also faced serious questions over the clemency plea of main accused in the terrorist attack on Parliament, Afzal Guru. The political right wing thought that he sat on the file and thereby did not reject the plea against the death penalty, and used it to attack him. He now, sensationally, says that the file was never even sent to him!

The biggest blot on his tenure was,

“He has been one of the BEST-LOVED and MOST-RESPECTED presidents.”

SOLI SORABJEE, FORMER ATTORNEY-GENERAL